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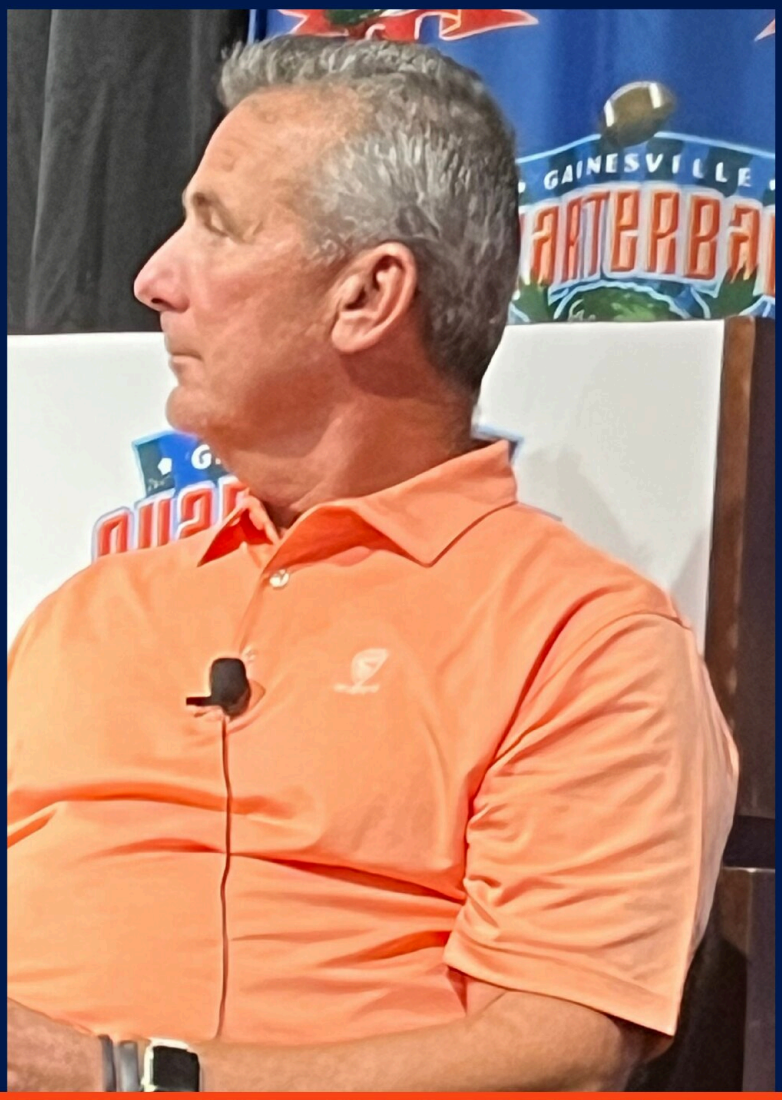
NOVEMBER 6, 2026

OKLAHOMA WEEK

URBAN MEYER

RING OF HONOR

A lasting place in The Swamp



INSIDE

Franz Beard's Oklahoma Soothsayer

Condon's near triple-double

The first CFP Top 25



Meyer: GatorBait archive | The Swamp: Chris Spears

GATORBAIT
MAGAZINE
Friday, Nov. 6, 2026 · Oklahoma week edition · Week 10, Oklahoma at Florida

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BEST FRIDAYS · BRENDEN MARTIN

Best Fridays: Urban Meyer Looks Back as Florida Turns Toward Oklahoma

Urban Meyer reflects on Florida's championship years and the current Gators; Edgar Thompson and Rob Dotson discuss Oklahoma and a strong basketball week on Best Fridays.

By Brenden Martin



Buddy Martin, left, interviews Urban Meyer in the taped conversation featured on Best Fridays. Video still: The Buddy Martin Show / Gator Bait Media.

Urban Meyer's return to Florida's football story led Friday morning's Best Fridays in Football with Buddy Martin, with a taped interview that moved from championship memories to the demands facing the current Gators.

The November 6 edition also featured Edgar Thompson on Florida's basketball win and the Oklahoma matchup, followed by Rob Dotson from the Panhandle. Franz Beard was scheduled, but Martin said at the close that he was unable to join.

Meyer's memories and his regret

In the interview with Martin, Meyer described what it means for former players to return with their families and see the history they helped make. He discussed his own family's part in the Ring of Honor weekend, then revisited the moments that stayed with him.

One was Jarvis Moss getting a hand on the field-goal attempt against South Carolina. Meyer described the result as pivotal to his Florida tenure.

"We lose that game. I don't think it ends well for coach Meyer, the coaching staff, and that team," he said.

He also recalled the preparation of the 2008 team that beat Georgia 49-10.

Asked what he would change about his time at Florida, Meyer talked about his departure and the toll of losing assistant coaches. His reflection also returned to the pace of chasing the next championship.

"I wish I would've enjoyed it more, buddy," Meyer said.

His view of the current Gators

Meyer drew a parallel between the current team and his first Florida team in 2005. He described a group whose best version can play at a high level, but which needs passion and energy to sustain it.

He also said there are positions to upgrade and expressed confidence that Jon Sumrall would address them. His message was about building from the team's best performances, with the Florida crowd providing energy.

Edgar Thompson on the frontcourt and Oklahoma

Thompson's basketball discussion focused on the Gators' frontcourt after the 88-57 win over Jacksonville. Alex Condon's near triple-double, Rueben Chinyelu's efficiency and Thomas Haugh's all-around play gave Martin and Thompson plenty to discuss. Thompson also pointed to Florida's perimeter shooting as a reason the offense has looked so effective.

On football, Thompson expected a physical, low-scoring game against Oklahoma. He emphasized that the Sooners still present a defensive challenge despite their offensive struggles. For Florida, he returned to the need for better offensive-line play and more help around the quarterback, while noting improvement on defense.

Thompson also discussed the excitement around Florida women's basketball and its new roster. The conversation gave Best Fridays a basketball focus alongside the football preview.

Rob Dotson closes from the Panhandle

Dotson joined Martin for the closing stretch, discussing Florida's remaining football opportunities, the Jacksonville basketball win and the enthusiasm among Gators fans in the Panhandle. He also described plans for a studio and the search for sponsors.

Martin closed by thanking Meyer, Thompson, Dotson and the production team. He said Beard had been up late writing and was unable to make the program.

THE BUDDY MARTIN SHOW · BRENDEN MARTIN

Tramell Jones Gets the Call: Buddy Martin Show Panel Backs Sumrall's QB Decision Before Oklahoma

The quarterback question that hung over Gainesville all week was the focus of Thursday night's Buddy Martin Show, where the panel backed what it viewed as Jon Sumrall's call.

By Brenden Martin



Aaron Philo, No. 12, at left, and Tramell Jones Jr., No. 9, at right, on Florida's sideline against South Carolina on Oct. 10, 2026. Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

The quarterback question that hung over Gainesville all week was the focus of Thursday night's Buddy Martin Show, where the panel backed what it viewed as Jon Sumrall's call.

The panel treated Tramell Jones Jr. as Florida's call at quarterback. Loren Meadows, on with Buddy from the top of the show, did not hedge.

"I think it was the right call," Meadows said. "Because I think with Florida's situation at that position, I think Tramell Jones gives you the better chance to win than Aaron Philo does."

Meadows went further, pointing at the huddle, not just the stat sheet: "The team plays better for Jones. The team wants to play for Jones."

And when the conversation turned to the noise around the decision — the suggestion that Jones is getting the job for the wrong reasons — Meadows shut it down in the line of the night: "If this is daddy ball, then every coach in America does daddy ball."

Buddy made the same point from the other side of the ball: the problems run deeper than one position. "This is an offense that is underachieving," he said. "It is not just

at the quarterback position."

MEYER AND THE RING OF HONOR

With Urban Meyer back in Gainesville this week, Buddy made his case plainly: "Urban Meyer deserves to be on the Ring of Honor. Nobody did it better, except for Spurrier."

That full conversation is cut as its own segment: watch the Urban Meyer Ring of Honor discussion.

THE PANEL FILLS OUT

Ben Troupe joined at the bottom of the hour and framed Saturday simply: give Florida a quarterback who can be "the captain of the offense and distribute the ball," and the Gators can play with Oklahoma. His game of the weekend, though, is elsewhere: Georgia-Ole Miss.

Paul Wilson Jr. closed the panel with the playoff picture. On Miami-Notre Dame, he was blunt: "Notre Dame is playing for its life." He picked a shootout, and Loren agreed — "I think it's going to be a 45 to 41 game."

On playoff expansion, the panel split. Wilson: "I think 24 teams. I think the regular season would not matter as much." Buddy's answer: "I think 16 is enough. I don't think you need 24." And on the era Florida fans grew up in, Meadows delivered the epitaph: "The days of dynasties are over. There is no dynasty anymore."

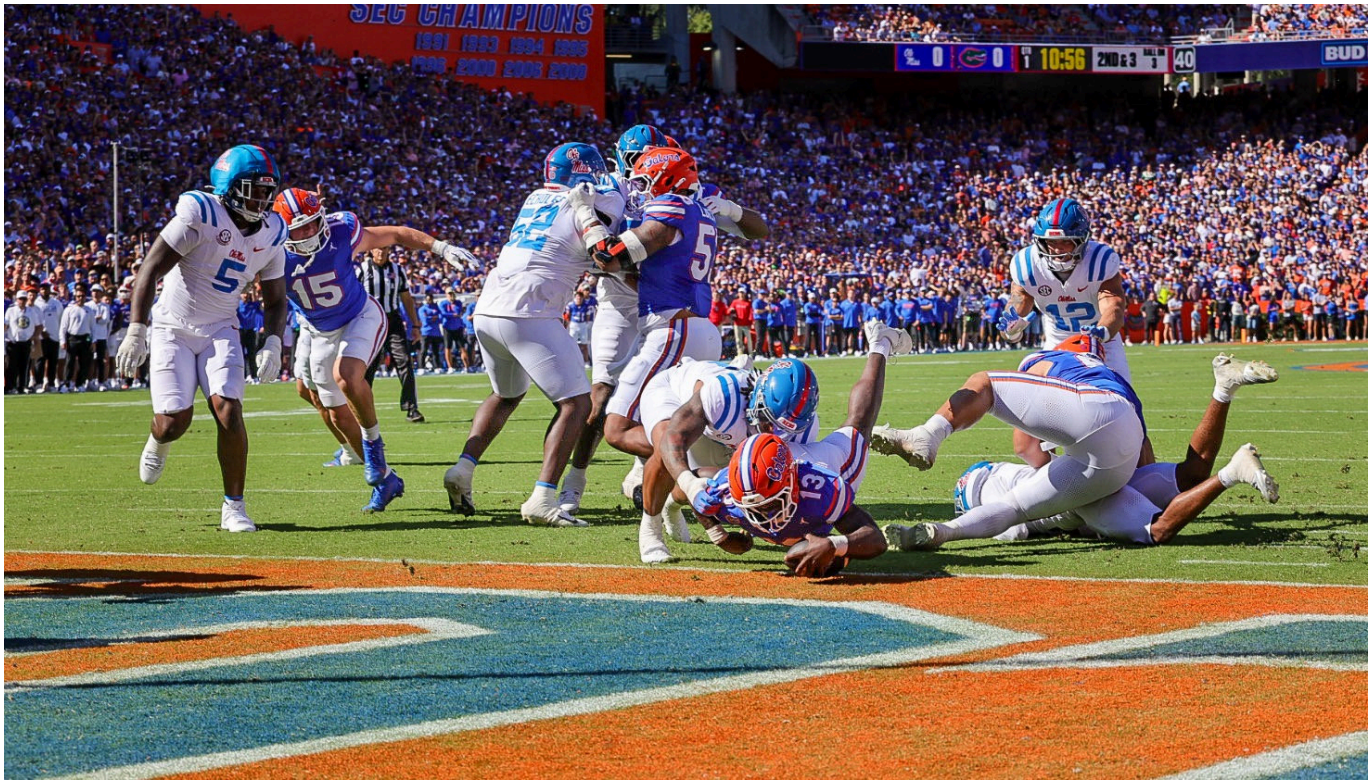
Florida hosts Oklahoma on Saturday night at The Swamp.

THE SOOTHSAYER · FRANZ BEARD

The Soothsayer likes the Gators in a white knuckler

Franz Beard likes Florida in a white knuckler against Oklahoma, with The Swamp making the difference. Plus his picks across the SEC.

By Franz Beard



Jadan Baugh dives into the end zone against Ole Miss in The Swamp on September 26, 2026. Archival photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

Desperate times call for desperate measures and in Norman, Oklahoma these are definitely desperate times.

That win three weeks ago over then No. 1 Texas only bought a short honeymoon which ended when Oklahoma (4-4, 2-3 SEC) got bitch-slapped into submission by South Carolina a week ago. Since then it has gone from honeymoon to hostility for head coach Brent Venables, who fired offensive coordinator Ben Arbuckle in an attempt to not only pacify boosters who want his head on a platter, but to salvage what's left of a season gone south.

When you find yourself strapped to a 40-gallon drum filled with high octane jet fuel and the boosters have an acetylene torch ready to make it go boom, you throw stuff against the wall hoping something will stick. That's what Venables did when he fired Arbuckle and named future Pro Football Hall of Fame tight end Jason Witten as his interim OC.

Witten, a first year Oklahoma assistant with no previous college coaching experience, gets to try his luck reviving Oklahoma's stagnant offense in The Swamp Saturday night against a Florida defense that has gotten progressively better since it went belly up the first week of October in Columbia, Missouri.

Oklahoma's offense under Arbuckle has been cloaked in predictability ever since he arrived from Washington State, bringing with him quarterback John Mateer.

Mateer played brilliantly at Wazzoo, but since transferring to the SEC the name of his game is inconsistency.

How much of Mateer's roller coaster ride against SEC defenses is a direct result of Arbuckle's play calling? And, how much of it has to do with a quarterback who can't fall back on a running game and whose offensive line has been hit hard by the injury bug?

Venables, who got a contract extension at the beginning of the year but now finds himself on a seat that grows warmer by the hour, has to hope that Witten has a bit of faith healer in him because this offense ranks next to last in the SEC and among the bottom 25 teams in all of Division I at 336.9 yards per game. Is a Florida defense that ranks 13th in the SEC the cure to what ails Oklahoma's offense?

Perhaps a better question has to do with the sudden change in play callers. Because Witten's coaching experience prior to Oklahoma was Liberty Christian School in Texas, there may be no readily available tape from which UF defensive coordinator Brad White can analyze and scheme accordingly. Will that lack of familiarity give Oklahoma the leg up it needs to outscore the Gators?

The flip side of all this is Florida's offense, which last eclipsed 400 yards in a game back in September. The Gators plan to start Tramell Jones Jr. at quarterback. He got a win on the road at Texas when the Longhorns were two weeks removed from the national No. 1 ranking. He didn't start against Georgia but came off the bench to lead the Gators to their only touchdown. He was noticeably more effective than Aaron Philo.

For the fifth straight week, it doesn't look like wide receiver Vernell Brown III will be available. He's listed as doubtful. Listed as questionable is Bailey Stockton, who leads the Gators with 35 catches for 365 yards. Out for the game is right tackle Emeka Ugorji, in the starting lineup for all eight previous games. In his place will be Caden Jones, a solid run blocker but shaky in pass protection.

All signs point to the outcome of this game coming down to which offense can find a measure of success. Oklahoma has the motivation of saving Brent Venables from joining Mike Norvell on the Extinct Species head coaching list. Florida, which has already surpassed the win total of Billy Napier's final year, has the motivation of a November that could set in motion a revival of the days when the Gators were a top ten fixture and a threat to compete for a national title.

The way the Soothsayer is analyzing Saturday night there will be no shortage of white knuckles and chest clutching on an eardrum shattering night at The Swamp.

THE SAYER SAYS SOOTH!: The Gators are favored by 6.5 points. The home field advantage will be the difference as Oklahoma's beleaguered offensive line might set records for false starts, forcing the Sooners to operate behind the chains.

As long as the Gators keep Mateer in the pocket, Oklahoma's offense will be neutralized. Look for Tramell Jones to loosen up the secondary enough that Jadan Baugh will find running room for his first 100-yard game since September. Florida gets bowl eligible and gains momentum for a November to remember.

THE SEC SOOTHSAYER

No. 2 Georgia (7-1, 5-1 SEC) at No. 10 Ole Miss (6-2, 4-2 SEC), 7:30 p.m., ABC:

For starters, the game is in Oxford where Ole Miss rarely loses. The Ole Miss offensive line is going to be the key here. The Rebels have allowed only five sacks all year, best in the SEC and fourth nationally. Trinidad Chambliss will make up for his bad day at the office in Austin a couple of weeks ago. The Sayer Says Sooth!: Georgia goes down creating a logjam for the top spot in the SEC.

No. 5 Alabama (6-2, 4-2 SEC) at No. 14 LSU (6-2, 3-2 SEC), 3:30 p.m., ABC:

Lane Kiffin has been lying awake at night dreaming of this matchup. The only thing missing is it's an afternoon game. At night, the LSU crowd would be seriously greased and ready to make life miserable for Alabama. He has just the defense to do it and an offense that can put a lot of points on the board. A third loss for Bama? The third straight season the Tide has lost three or more? Bear Bryant is rolling over in his grave and Nick Saban is seen stopping on the side of the road to barf while driving to one of his Mercedes dealerships. The Sayer Says Sooth!: It's a playoff elimination game and LSU stays alive while Alabama faithful scream for Kalen DeBoer's scalp.

No. 6 Kentucky (7-1, 5-1 SEC) at No. 13 Tennessee (6-2, 3-2 SEC), 6:15 p.m., ESPN:

The Kentucky Cinderella story travels to Knoxville where a Tennessee defense leads the nation in sacks (35). The Vols will also play defense with their offense, running the ball and controlling the clock. Kentucky will make it close for three quarters, then the Vols will dominate at the end. Tennessee is favored by six.

The Sayer Says Sooth!: The Vols won't score a lot of points, just enough to become another two-loss team clamoring for the SEC championship.

No. 7 Texas (6-2, 3-2 SEC) at No. 18 Missouri (6-2, 3-2 SEC), 12 noon, ESPN:

It's an elimination game for both teams. The winner stays in the hunt for the SEC title and the College Football Playoff. The loser gets a third loss and a bowl game in Orlando or Tampa. Texas is favored by 2.5-points. Missouri, meanwhile, has a healthy Ahmad Hardy ready to spring loose. If he can run the ball, Mizzou has a chance. If not, the Longhorns stay alive.

The Sayer Says Sooth!: Arch Manning remembers to throw the ball to his own team, the Longhorns stuff the Mizzou run and emerge as a contender.

Texas A&M (4-4, 1-4 SEC) at No. 21 South Carolina (5-3, 3-3 SEC), 3 p.m., ESPN:

South Carolina is scorching hot and the Aggies are leftovers in the fridge growing mold by the second. The Gamecocks have won three in a row with an offense clicking behind LaNorris Sellers and a defense that has gone four straight games without yielding 400 yards. The Aggies are the most disappointing team in the SEC in large part because Marcel Reed has underwhelmed at quarterback.

The defense is good at home, but this one is on the road where the Aggies have been porous. The Sayer Says Sooth!: LaNorris Sellers has quietly become the second best QB in the SEC behind Trinidad Chambliss. He's the difference-maker for the Chickens who think a nine-win season is achievable.

Arkansas (3-5, 1-4 SEC) at Auburn (4-4, 2-4 SEC), 12:45 p.m., SEC Network:

That win over Georgia when the Bulldogs were No. 1 in the country is a dot in the rearview for Auburn, which has lost two straight in blowout fashion. This is a get well game for the Tigers who will be double digit favorites in each of the next three games. For Arkansas, it's another loss in a season that can't end fast enough. The Sayer Says Sooth!: If this game gets interesting it will be because Byrum Brown is turning the ball over. Expect a big game from Brown and for Auburn's defense to actually have a decent game.

Vanderbilt (3-5, 0-5 SEC) at Mississippi State (4-4, 2-4 SEC), 4:15 p.m., SEC Network:

How weird is this? AJ Swann, whose career began at Vanderbilt five years ago gets to start against his former alma mammy. With Kamario Taylor healthy, Mississippi State was a legitimate force on its way to a nine win season. Without him the Bulldogs have produced a combined 18 points in the last three games. For Vandy the motivation is to break a five game losing streak in SEC play and avoid an oh-fer season in league play.

The Sayer Says Sooth!: With Taylor healthy this is a no-brainer. Without him Mississippi State is downright bad on offense. As a result, the Fighting Clark Leas get their first SEC win of the year.

MEN'S BASKETBALL · FRANZ BEARD

Condon flirts with triple-double as Gators smack JU

Franz Beard on Alex Condon's near triple-double, Rueben Chinyelu's career-high 21 points and No. 1 Florida's 88-57 win over Jacksonville.

By Franz Beard



Photo by Chris Spears, GatorBait Media.

With Alex Condon flirting with a rare Florida triple-double, Rueben Chinyelu had the perfect solution to what might have been an historic night.

"Rueben was telling me just throw me the ball, it's an automatic assist," Condon said Thursday night after he scored 12 points, grabbed 12 rebounds and handed out eight assists as No. 1 Florida moved to 2-0 on the young season with an 88-57 win over the Jacksonville Dolphins at the O-Dome.

If Chinyelu got the ball in the low blocks there was every good chance the ball was either going in the basket or else he got fouled. His size alone (6-10, 265 pounds) made him an easy target for which JU had no one to match. One-on-one was a disaster, so the Dolphins surrounding Chinyelu any time he got the ball within five feet of the basket. Double teams didn't work, nor did triple teams.

Chinyelu put up a career-high 21 points on 7-9 shooting from the field along with 7-9 from the foul line. He also grabbed eight rebounds, handed out an assist and blocked a shot. All in a rather good day at the office for the senior from Nigeria.

Chinyelu was at his overpowering best, but so were Condon and Tommy Haugh. Florida's three front line guys combined for 47 points, 27 rebounds, 13 assists, a steal and four blocked shots. Together they shot 15-23 from the field overall, 3-6 from three and 14-17 from the foul line.

Condon's flirtation with the triple-double included 2-3 shooting from the field including 1-2 from three and 5-6 from the foul line. On the bench, Todd Golden and the Florida staff were aware how close Condon was to the triple-double but he went to the bench for good with 10:32 left in the game.

"There was a thought, but at the end of the day, a big thing that we talked about going into this game was that was this is all about us and playing towards a standard and not worrying about individual success," Golden said. "So, it'd be a little counter intuitive in that moment to kind of leave him in there and get an individual statistic when we were playing for the team and for the standard. Could've, maybe should've, but I think he'll have other opportunities this year where he might be getting close to triple-doubles."

Had he stayed in the game longer, Haugh might have had similar numbers to Condon. He filled up the stat sheet with 14 points, seven rebounds, four assists and a steal. He made 5-8 of his shots including 2-4 from three-point range.

More often than not, whenever Haugh or Condon grabbed a rebound on the defensive end they put the ball on the deck rather than outlet the ball to start the Gators in transition. The Gators consistently beat Jacksonville down the floor as the Gators were able to set up the offense before the Dolphins could get their defense set. It was a case of too much Florida size, speed, strength and athleticism for Jacksonville to handle.

"They're [Haugh and Condon] both really athletic," Florida coach Todd Golden said. "They're both very capable decisionmakers. With the transition push, I do think it's more challenging for teams to stop them in transition when a front court player is bringing it up if they're capable of doing that because they get in some mismatches in terms of their matchups. So, obviously, those guys have my trust, and I believe in their ability to make decisions in transition, and it kind of gives us another element offensively."

Florida's ability to spread the floor to create great passing angles opened up the outside for Denzel Aberdeen and lethal weapon three shooter Urban Klavzar who played nearly 20 minutes off the bench. Aberdeen hit 4-5 on threes while grabbing two rebounds and contributing a steal on defense. Klavzar, last year's SEC Sixth Man of the Year, also contributed 12 points while hitting 3-5 on threes. It wasn't a big night from a numbers standpoint for starting point guard Boogie Fland (four points, one rebound, three assists), but this was a night when he didn't need to score. He just kept the ball moving and blew by JU defenders.

To Jacksonville's credit, the Dolphins hung around with the Gators until the final five minutes of the first half. Almost as if they had a let's put an end to this nonsense switch, the Gators went on a 19-2 tear to end the half, taking a 31-26 lead to 50-28 at the intermission.

Haugh got things started with a layup off a pass from the top of the key from Condon. During the scoring run, Haugh added a three off a pass from Chinyelu. Aberdeen hit two threes, the second off a pass from Haugh. Condon delivered a dunk back off a missed layup and a floater in the lane on an assist from Klavzar. Chinyelu punctuated the outburst with a thunderous dunk with 27 seconds to go in the half.

"Jacksonville, I thought, did a good job in the first half just slowing tempo and kinda keeping that game within reach," Golden said. "And then, obviously, the last four minutes of the first half, I just think we wore them down a little bit, making some shots and turning misses into transition opportunities and got that lead up to 22 pretty quick. Played the right way in the second half with the exception of a couple of early turnovers. Their [Jacksonville] bigs hit a couple threes early, which wasn't ideal, but the back-half of the second half, I thought we guarded very, very well."

For the second straight game, the Gators played outstanding defense, holding JU to 19-57 shooting from the field and just 6-21 from the three-point line. The Gators outrebounded the Dolphins 51-25. In the paint, the Gators outscored the Dolphins 36-12 with a 23-11 advantage in second chance points. The Gators got 25 points from the bench with Klavzar (12), Isaiah Brown (4) and AJ Brown (3) leading the way.

Three-point shooting, a perceived weakness during Florida's three exhibition games, was, for the second straight game, a highlight for the Gators. They hit 11-26 against Miami back on Monday night and followed that up

with 11-25 against Jacksonville. The Gators started slowly from the three-point line a year ago, so a 22-51 start should be a sign of good things to come.

"It's a big part of what we need to be the best team we can be," Golden said. "I think we're taking the right ones. We're not forcing a ton of threes. They're coming in our offense or in transition and we have the right guys taking them. If that continues I think we'll continue to shoot the ball well all year."

In the win over Miami, the Gators made only 20-35 of their free throws. Florida's 19-27 effort Thursday included 4-8 shooting off the bench from Arturas Butajevas (1-2), Viktor Mikic (2-4) and Alex Kovatchev (1-2).

Next up for the Gators is a trip to Tallahassee for the annual matchup with Florida State. The Seminoles (1-0), who started their season with a win over Florida A&M back on Monday, face Troy tonight.

WOMEN'S BASKETBALL · LOREN MEADOWS

Showtime at the O'Dome: McMiller's Career-High 42 Powers Florida Past UCF, 95-65

Kiyomi McMiller scored a career-high 42 points and Vivian Iwuchukwu added 20 as Florida rolled past UCF 95-65 in Gainesville.

By Loren Meadows, GatorBaitMedia.com and host of The Gator Lowdown with Loren Meadows

> **"Just keep going until they stop me. It just feels like you can't miss. Anything you put up is going in."**
>
> — KIYOMI MCMILLER

This evening, Florida's basketball teams took part in a rare doubleheader that saw the Florida women take on UCF, followed by the top-ranked men's basketball team facing Jacksonville and former Florida assistant Jordan Mincey. While fans, including the Rowdy Reptiles, showed up to get a good seat for the men's home opener, what they got was an Allen Iverson-, Dawn Staley- and Caitlin Clark-like show from junior point guard Kiyomi McMiller. The second-team preseason All-SEC pick from Silver Springs, Maryland, was all in her bag tonight with a quick first step, elite ball handling and efficient scoring on her way to a career-high 42-point explosion that led Florida to a 95-65 win over UCF. McMiller's 42 points were the fourth-highest output in Gators history. Following a 31-point effort Monday against Bucknell, she became just the fifth player in school history to score 30 or more points in back-to-back games.

McMiller was electric, and the Rowdy Reptiles chanted "32! 32!" in appreciation of her effort. As the point total grew to 37, the chant changed to "40! 40!" in anticipation of the career milestone. With the swish of a wing three, the student section went into a frenzy and McMiller boldly introduced herself to the Gator faithful. When discussing her historic night, McMiller said:

> *"I think it was big for me to get my three-ball going early. I think it gave us all energy, just coming out and knocking that down off the jump. From the beginning our mindset was to kill 'em and don't stop. Just keep attacking them, and attacking them, and attacking them. Just keep going until they stop me. It just feels like you can't miss. Anything you put up is going in."*

While McMiller was dealing from the perimeter, her partner in crime, Vivian Iwuchukwu, was handling business down low with a career-high 20 points on 6-of-7 shooting from the field and 8-of-12 from the free-throw line. Iwuchukwu averaged just 2.9 points per game last season in a more workmanlike role at USC. She has been asked to take on more of an offensive role with the Gators and credits her offseason work for the increased output:

> *"It all started from the summertime. Obviously, this is a new role for me, but the coaches really prepared me to excel in the role. All summer, I really worked on that. Worked on my craft, my game, one-on-one, knowing when to kick it out. But I'm molding in it so well because I prepared all summer for it."*

Regardless of the performances, what coach Tammi Reiss was most pleased with was the energy of both her team and the O'Dome crowd:

"You know I love being a part of Gator Nation, the Gator family. It's one of the greatest sports environments in college athletics. The brand is unbelievable, so I want them coming out and supporting us. They come out to every sport here — you see them at softball, volleyball, baseball. So I love the fact that they knew it was a doubleheader and they came to get their seats for the men's game, but I am hoping, like Vivian said, you build it brick by brick and then by the time you're competing for championships, this O'Dome is sold out. That is our goal, seat by seat, fan by fan, but there is nothing like having students. It is a different atmosphere. I love the ruckus and I hope they keep coming out and supporting us."

The Florida women will take the show on the road for the first time this season when they face Chattanooga on Sunday at 2 p.m. ET on SEC Network+.

FIRST CFP RANKINGS · GATORBAIT STAFF

Gators No. 24 in First CFP Top 25 as Miami, Georgia Lead the Way

Florida (5-3) is No. 24 in the first College Football Playoff rankings, one of 10 SEC teams in the Top 25. Miami, Georgia, Utah and Indiana hold the top four spots.

By GatorBait Staff



Graphic: GatorBait Media.

The first College Football Playoff rankings of the 2026 season are out, and the Florida Gators are in them, with everything still in front of them.

Florida (5-3) checked in at No. 24 in the selection committee's first Top 25, released Tuesday night. The Gators are one of 10 SEC teams in the rankings, the most of any conference.

Miami (8-0) took the No. 1 spot, followed by Georgia (7-1), Utah (8-0) and Indiana (8-1). Those four would earn the first-round byes if the playoff started today.

The rest of the top 12: No. 5 Alabama (6-2), No. 6 Kentucky (7-1), No. 7 Texas (6-2), No. 8 UCLA (8-0), No. 9 BYU (7-1), No. 10 Ole Miss (6-2), No. 11 Notre Dame (7-1) and No. 12 Ohio State (6-2). Because No. 25 Boise State (7-1) is the highest-ranked Group of Six team, the Broncos would take the 12th spot in the bracket, leaving Ohio State and No. 13 Tennessee as the first two teams out.

The SEC's 10 ranked teams: Georgia (2), Alabama (5), Kentucky (6), Texas (7), Ole Miss (10), Tennessee (13), LSU (14), Missouri (18), South Carolina (21) and Florida (24).

The rest of the Top 25: No. 14 LSU (6-2), No. 15 Texas Tech (7-1), No. 16 Wake Forest (7-1), No. 17 Houston (6-2), No. 18 Missouri (6-2), No. 19 Iowa (6-2), No. 20 USC (7-2), No. 21 South Carolina (5-3), No. 22 Arizona (6-2), No. 23 Oregon (5-3), No. 24 Florida (5-3) and No. 25 Boise State (7-1).

Florida's road is narrow, but it is real. The Gators host Oklahoma on Saturday at 7:45 p.m. ET on SEC Network, and a win there starts the climb. The committee releases new rankings every Tuesday night, with the final 12-team field announced Sunday, Dec. 6.

So where do you have them? Is No. 24 too low for a team that went into Austin and beat Texas? Tell us in the comments below.

COLUMN · BUDDY MARTIN

The Golden Goose Needs A Checkup — And The Schooner Stays Home

Buddy Martin examines college football's television economy, the SEC's ratings power, Florida's Playoff ranking and why the Sooner Schooner will not be in The Swamp.

By Buddy Martin

> **My diagnosis: The SEC isn't killing the sport. But the people getting rich off it ought to quit confusing a healthy bank account with a healthy patient.**
>
> BUDDY MARTIN, COLUMN

The Golden Goose is not dead yet.

But it needs an appointment at the Mayo Clinic, and the specialist keeps rescheduling.

Some say the SEC is killing college football. Others say ESPN is in bed with the SEC. Still others say the SEC is what makes college football worth watching.

Who's right? There's enough truth in all three to get everybody subpoenaed.

My diagnosis: The SEC isn't killing the sport. But the people getting rich off it ought to quit confusing a healthy bank account with a healthy patient.

One exam needs a stethoscope. The other just needs an accountant who works Saturdays.

Count the eyeballs before you count the mourners

Through Week 8, games on ABC, NBC, CBS, Fox and ESPN averaged 3.3 million viewers, down 6 percent from 3.5 million a year ago. NBC and CBS were down double digits. Fox was the only network that didn't bleed.

That's a warning light, not a death certificate.

There's also a wrinkle: Nielsen changed its measuring stick. Since September 2025 it's been counting 45 million smart-TV households along with the old panel, and that alone produced a 7.5 percent baseline lift. Last season's celebrated 11 percent growth was partly football and partly a better census. You can't put taller heels on the drum major and announce the whole band grew.

Still, 22 games drew 10 million viewers last season against eight two years earlier. Those weren't imaginary customers. The question is whether the sport can keep them without making Saturdays so aggravating that viewers switch to something less stressful — like arguing with their insurance company.

The SEC's patient is eating well

While the rest of the neighborhood checks the thermostat, the SEC is turning up the air conditioning. SEC-controlled games averaged 5.3 million viewers, slightly ahead of last year. The Big Ten was at 3.6 million and down 10 percent. The Big 12, by the way, was up 9 percent — so this isn't the SEC flourishing while everyone else sinks.

Then came Florida-Georgia. About 7.1 million watched on ABC, tops for Week 9. Ohio State-USC drew 6.6 million.

Minnesota-Indiana, 4.9. Miami-North Carolina, 4.6.

So no, Florida isn't killing the ratings. Georgia merely tried to kill Florida's afternoon, and America stayed to watch the Gators do it through a welder's mask.

That's the SEC's argument in one uncomfortable photograph: these games draw even when one team does all the drawing and the other is looking for an eraser.

In bed? There's a contract on the nightstand

As for ESPN being in bed with the SEC — fellas, this isn't a secret romance.

They sent out a press release. ESPN owns the SEC's television rights, wants its investment to succeed, and has a megaphone that can be heard from Gainesville to the space station.

That's not proof the rankings are fixed. It's a very good reason the committee should explain itself in plain English, so fans don't have to consult a conspiracy podcast.

Florida supplies this week's exhibit: 5-3 and No. 24 in the first Playoff rankings. A critic sees SEC favoritism. A Gator sees a brutal schedule. The committee owes both of them a better explanation than "trust us."

What fans are really saying

The complaints sound contradictory until you listen closely. Fans want meaningful games, but they also want their team alive after losing one.

They want continuity, but they want a new quarterback via the portal by Thursday. They want players treated fairly, but they flinch when the starting lineup resembles the departure board at Hartsfield-Jackson.

That's not hypocrisy. That's being in love with something that keeps changing the terms of the relationship.

Here's my suspicion: the sport's most dangerous opponent isn't the SEC, the portal or the playoff.

It's exhaustion.

A touchdown. A commercial. A kickoff. Another commercial. At some point the football starts looking like an interruption in a pharmaceutical convention.

Give the fans heavyweight fights and they still show up — top-10 matchups are up 6 percent. It's the four-hour hearings on who gets the last Playoff invitation that put them to sleep.

Saturday night in the Swamp

Which brings us to Oklahoma's first visit to Ben Hill Griffin Stadium, and the unhappy news that the Sooner Schooner will not be attending.

The Schooner, for the unfamiliar, is a covered wagon pulled by two ponies named Boomer and Sooner. It performs at home games in Norman, select special events, and the Red River Rivalry in Dallas — where, in a triumph of Cotton Bowl logistics, it doesn't actually run on the field. Road trips to Gainesville are not on the itinerary.

This is a shame, because Florida fans have been looking forward to seeing it.

And let's be honest: even if the Schooner did travel, it couldn't get out of the shop in time. Not after the wreck of a season Brent Venables has had — a campaign so battered that the only thing keeping it out of the impound lot is the win over Texas. When your season is a write-off, you don't send the wagon. You send the tow truck.

The Sooners arrive at 4-4, which in Norman these days is known as "rebuilding" and everywhere else is known as "4-4."

Florida, 5-3 after the head-knocking from Georgia, has a chance to walk in the back door of bowl eligibility with a sixth win. No, that isn't where Florida once measured success. There was a time when six victories meant checking how many Saturdays were left, not checking postseason travel arrangements. But progress is measured from where you stand, not from where the championship photographs hang.

And Saturday, one of the men responsible for those photographs comes home.

Urban Meyer enters the Ring of Honor at halftime, recognized for the 2006 and 2008 national championships. I talked to Urban this week — he's excited. He told me there had been chances before, but this was the time.

He proudly told me, "You know, Nicki, my oldest daughter, lived with us, and I have six grandkids now. And I just found out she's going to bring two of the oldest ones to the game on Saturday as a surprise.

“I used to always tell our players that this was my goal really at every job, especially a job like Florida, when I was there, but also every other program that the former players that you see most often are the players from the national championship team under coach Spurrier.

“James Bates, etc. That whole team, you saw a lot of them. “And then there'd be time in history where you just wouldn't see many former players come around. And the reality is they never really won that championship.

“I got to see so many of coach Spurrier's players because they would love to come back and see their name on the walls, see…and show their kids, and someday show their grandchildren.

“And I would tell our players that all the time. “It’s kind of funny. I get those text messages from our players now that they can't wait to bring their their son, their daughter, their wife back and, and experience what they did.”

There’s a certain poetry in Meyer’s name going up while Oklahoma is in the building. His second national championship came at the Sooners’ expense. Somewhere in Norman, they know that, and it’s one more reason the Schooner stayed home.

Back to the Golden Goose

College football doesn’t need an obituary. It needs people in charge who understand that loyalty is not an inexhaustible natural resource.

Give fans games worth watching. Preserve connections worth caring about. Leave enough football between the commercials that people remember why they turned the set on.

The Golden Goose can still recover. Just don’t let the television executives handle the appointment. They’ll make the exam last four hours, sell naming rights to the thermometer, and put the goose in a prime-time window against the World Series.

COLUMN · BUDDY MARTIN

Apples, Oranges and Fielding Yost

Buddy Martin on Sports Illustrated's all-time coaches list: Saban at No. 1 is right, but ranking Fielding Yost against the modern game is apples and oranges.

By Buddy Martin

> **You cannot rank coaches across eras any more than you can rank fruit across the produce aisle.**
>
> BUDDY MARTIN, COLUMN

Another clickbait list tries to rank coaches across a century — and fails. Give me Saban, Meyer, Spurrier, Bowden and let's talk!

Sports Illustrated just published a list of the 25 greatest coaches in college football history, and I want to be fair about this, so let me start with the good news: They got No. 1 right. Nick Saban at the top is the easiest call on the whole board.

Seven national championships, spread across two schools and three decades, won under every format, every rulebook and every excuse the modern game could invent. If you want to argue about Saban, argue with the wall.

After that, friends, the list falls off a cliff and keeps rolling. Garbage!

Let me deal with the matter at hand, because it cuts to the heart of everything wrong with these lists.

Somewhere below Bo Schembechler and Lou Holtz, at No. 20, sits Fielding H. Yost. And I have one simple question for the three gentlemen who wrote this thing: Which of you saw him coach?

Yost's last game at Michigan was in 1926. One hundred years ago. No writer on that byline was alive when Yost coached. They are ranking a man none of them ever watched take a snap, against competition nobody can measure, from an era when there were no polls, no film worth the name, and — for most of Yost's "national championships" in 1901, 1902, 1903 and 1904 — not even a forward pass.

It was against the rules.

Yost's Wolverines scored 100 points in a game four times against the likes of Buffalo and West Virginia. And I'm supposed to slot that somewhere between Lou Holtz and LaVell Edwards with a straight face? That's not analysis. That's reading old newspaper clippings and typing "30."

Here's the problem with all of it, and it's the same problem I've abhorred for more than a half century: You cannot rank coaches across eras any more than you can rank fruit across the produce aisle.

I admire and respect the attempt by younger people to embrace those of different eras, not copping out by saying "I don't know — I wasn't born yet!" Then again, it has gone too far. Quit pretending you know what you don't know.

It's apples and oranges, folks, and I'm begging the list-makers of America to stop pretending otherwise. It's fake precision. A ranking implies you measured something. You didn't. You compared a leather-helmet era when the forward pass was illegal to a NIL era when the quarterback has a business manager.

Those two things do not go on the same scale. They don't even go in the same store.

Want proof of how fake the scale is? Look what happens when you try to use it. Oklahoma occupies three of the top six spots — Wilkinson at 5, Switzer at 6, with Osborne's Nebraska at 4 for good measure. Fine

programs all. But Barry Switzer's Sooners won 12 Big Eight titles in a 16-year run when that conference had, what, two other teams that mattered?

Meanwhile Bobby Bowden, who built a national power out of a program that went 4-29 before he got there, sits at No. 7 behind him. Urban Meyer — three national titles at two schools, .854 winning percentage — is No. 10, two spots behind John McKay. Steve Spurrier, who took a Florida program that had never sniffed an SEC title, won six of them plus a national championship, and revolutionized the passing game on the side, is No. 15 — behind Darrell Royal, behind LaVell Edwards, behind Ara Parseghian.

The writers didn't do this because they're dumb. They did it because the exercise is impossible. When the tool is broken, everything you build with it is crooked.

And now the poison has spread to the present tense. Curt Cignetti is on the all-time list. The ALL-TIME list. The man has been relevant for about two seasons.

Yes, what he did at Indiana is remarkable, and if he keeps it up for 15 years, we'll talk. But he's on the same list as Bear Bryant and Eddie Robinson — a coach who spent 57 years at one school and won 408 games under conditions Bryant never had to face, segregation chief among them. That's not a hot take, that's a hot mess.

Recency bias isn't a ranking criterion, no matter what the internet tells you.

Now, before the letters and emails arrive: I'm all for remembering the greats. Yost, Stagg, Warner, Rockne — those men built the house we all live in, and I've spent a good chunk of my life writing about exactly that. Stagg invented the huddle. Warner invented half the plays still run on Friday nights. They deserve every plaque in every hall of fame. What they don't deserve is a numbered slot between coaches whose games we can actually evaluate.

I watched Bear Bryant pace a sideline in person. I covered Spurrier's Gators, sat in Bowden's press conferences, saw the eras collide in the 1990s when the SEC grew teeth. I feel qualified to compare the coaches I watched. I am not qualified — and neither is anyone at SI — to tell you whether Fielding Yost's 55-1-1 run against a schedule of farmers' colleges stacks up against Saban's 17-year reign of terror in the toughest conference in America. Nobody is. The men who might have told us died before the people who wrote this list were born.

So here's the verdict, and I'll keep it short: Rank each coach against his own era. That's a fair fight. Yost owned his. Rockne owned his. Wilkinson, Bryant, Robinson, Paterno — measure them against their contemporaries and let them stand or fall there.

If you want to compare decades — the '60s coaches against the '60s coaches, the playoff era against the playoff era — fine, have at it. That's real work and I'll read every word.

But this business of blending 1902 and 2026 into one numbered list? That's not history. That's arithmetic dressed up as insight. It's fake, folks.

Stop it!

The greatest coach in college football history is whoever dominated his era the most completely, and after that, the argument is a bar argument — which, come to think of it, is the only proper place for it.

CREDITS

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